

Research Brief: SkillForge Online Learning Feature Prioritisation

Background & Context

SkillForge is an early-stage online corporate learning platform built around short adaptive modules, gamified assessments, third-party content, and potential additions such as collaboration, AI-driven skill-gap analytics, mentorship, certified-course bundles, reminders, and personalised learning plans. The immediate business trigger is the need to decide which feature opportunities should enter product design and development before engineering, content, partnership, pricing, or certification investments become expensive to change.

The market context makes this decision timely. One commercial estimate values India's learning-management-system market at USD 1.86 billion in 2025 and projects it to reach USD 5.06 billion by 2034, although this should be treated as directional market context rather than a definitive SkillForge TAM estimate. — Straits Research (straitsresearch.com) Coursera for Business currently promotes learning paths, skill tracking, proficiency testing, learner tracking, and an interactive AI guide, meaning SkillForge's skill-gap analytics must be evaluated for actionable personalisation rather than simple reporting. — Coursera for Business (coursera.org)

Demand for job-relevant and AI-related learning is also strengthening. Reporting on Coursera's 2025 Global Skills Report indicated a 107% year-on-year rise in generative-AI enrolments in India and more than 2.6 million Indian learners on the platform. — ETCIO reporting on Coursera's report (cio.economictimes.indiatimes.com) Udemy's enterprise research, based on nearly 17,000 customers, highlights demand for practical generative-AI applications alongside soft skills and leadership development. — Udemy Business (about.udemy.com)

The competitive frame is already demanding. LinkedIn's 2025 India Workplace Learning Report connects AI adoption, career development, manager support, and individual growth, while upGrad promotes live sessions, doubt-clearing support, industry certifications, mentorship, and career support in India. — LinkedIn Learning (learning.linkedin.com) — upGrad (upgrad.com) The research therefore needs to determine whether SkillForge can differentiate through better completion support, more trusted personalisation, stronger workplace application, or a more valuable subscription bundle.

Research Objectives

Based on the approved strategic framework, this study will answer the following business questions.

Strategic Objectives

1. Validate the learner problems and unmet needs that SkillForge should address in order to improve engagement, course completion, and repeat learning.
2. Prioritise the one to three feature areas that should enter SkillForge's next product-design or prototype phase.
3. Determine whether a subscription combining certified courses and mentorship has sufficient differentiated value to justify further pricing and packaging work.
4. Assess whether SkillForge can compete through practical workplace application, career development, trusted personalisation, and completion support.

Tactical Objectives

1. Map learning frequency, session length, device context, time of day, course topics, and self-directed versus employer-supported learning occasions.
2. Quantify the course-completion funnel from enrolment and first-module start through milestone progress, assessment completion, certification, and repeat-course behaviour.
3. Identify the main causes of non-completion, including time pressure, unclear goals, content difficulty, weak relevance, poor discovery, limited feedback, weak reminders, lack of accountability, and competing work demands.
4. Measure how active learners, lapsed learners, prospective learners, users of other platforms, educators, and course creators differ in needs and feature expectations.
5. Prioritise collaboration, AI skill-gap analytics, certified-course bundles, mentorship, recommendations, reminders, learning plans, community, assessments, progress tracking, and doubt resolution using MaxDiff where the final list contains five or more opportunities.
6. Assess the perceived usefulness, expected impact, trust, explainability, and control requirements associated with AI-driven skill-gap analytics.
7. Separate the value of live mentoring, asynchronous doubt resolution, peer discussion, group projects, live classes, and real-time collaboration rather than treating them as one social-learning construct.
8. Measure whether industry certification is viewed as a completion motivator, a workplace signal, a career-development tool, or a basic expectation.
9. Evaluate the perceived value, renewal appeal, preferred payment structure, and acceptable price range for a certified-course-plus-mentorship subscription.
10. Validate whether clearer learning plans, personalised recommendations, and reminders are associated with higher intended completion and repeat learning.
11. Determine whether learners prefer SkillForge's AI analytics to support individual guidance, manager reporting, or both.
12. Identify switching barriers, trust risks, content gaps, and adoption friction that could limit SkillForge's ability to displace existing learning platforms.

13. Capture educator and course-creator perspectives on content quality, learner drop-off, assessment design, mentoring requirements, community delivery, and operational feasibility.
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Type of Study

We will conduct a Mixed Methodology study combining Usage & Attitude, Feature/Message Prioritisation, and exploratory Pricing Research.

This is primarily a U&A study because SkillForge first needs a behavioural baseline: who learns online, how often they learn, where they drop off, and what prevents completion. It includes a feature-prioritisation module because the business decision is roadmap ranking rather than evaluation of finished designs. It also includes an exploratory pricing module because a certified-course-plus-mentorship subscription is under consideration, but no final price architecture has yet been approved.

Survey Design Approach (Marketing Research Methodology)

The selected design is a linear structured questionnaire with a modular funnel and an embedded MaxDiff exercise, followed by a light pricing module. The approved framework specifies zero finished discrete stimuli because SkillForge has no final designs, prototypes, advertisements, or developed feature executions. Under the methodology decision framework, zero stimuli means cell-based designs such as monadic, sequential monadic, A/B, paired comparison, or split-cell testing are not appropriate.

The survey will begin with actual learning behaviour and completion experience, then explore unaided barriers before introducing concise, neutral descriptions of feature areas. Feature prioritisation will use MaxDiff / Best-Worst Scaling if at least five distinct feature opportunities remain after consolidation. This will create a relative preference hierarchy and reduce the positive-end response bias that can occur when Indian respondents rate every feature as useful. A light Van Westendorp Price Sensitivity Meter module is appropriate if SkillForge has no candidate prices; if specific INR price points are later approved, the pricing module can be changed to Gabor-Granger.

The design will route current SkillForge users, active users of other platforms, lapsed learners, prospective learners, and educators or course creators into relevant modules. Educator responses will be analysed separately from learner outcomes. Feature and attribute order will be randomised, with block rotation for larger batteries. Behavioural questions will precede attitudinal evaluation, and high-value open-ended probes will be used after key ratings rather than after every item.

Alternatives considered:

- Sequential Monadic: Not chosen because there are no finished concepts or feature executions requiring independent absolute evaluation.
- Side-by-Side Feature Comparison: Not chosen because it would encourage superficial comparison and would not diagnose current learning behaviour or completion barriers.
- Choice-Based Conjoint: Not chosen for this first study because SkillForge has not yet established realistic feature families, attribute levels, or price levels for configuration trade-offs.

Survey Routing Logic: Skip logic will bypass irrelevant questions; branching will separate learners from educators; display logic will show follow-ups based on prior behaviour; termination logic will remove respondents who do not meet eligibility criteria; and filter logic will support follow-ups on previously selected platforms, barriers, or feature areas.

Quality Controls: The survey will include attention checks at approximately a 1:9 ratio, speed checks against the median completion time, straight-line detection in rating batteries, consistency checks comparing reported learning frequency with recent completion behaviour, and open-ended response screening for gibberish or irrelevant text. Fully labelled five-point scales, behavioural anchors, forced trade-offs, and neutral wording will be used to reduce acquiescence and courtesy bias among Indian respondents.

You can request a different methodology before generating the survey.

Question Flow & Survey Phases

The questionnaire will be designed for approximately 20–25 questions and an 8–12 minute smartphone completion experience.

- Phase 1 — Warm-Up & Screening: Confirm recent online-learning behaviour, learner or educator role, SkillForge usage status, and platform familiarity. This establishes respondent credibility without re-collecting audience demographics enforced by SuperJ targeting.
- Phase 2 — Learning Context & Usage Behaviour: Capture learning frequency, session length, device context, time of day, course topics, learning goals, discovery routes, and employer support. This creates the behavioural baseline for interpreting feature needs.
- Phase 3 — Completion Funnel & Drop-Off Diagnosis: Measure enrolment, first-module start, progress milestones, assessment completion, certification, repeat learning, and unfinished-course experience. Explore the strongest barriers and the specific point where engagement declines.
- Phase 4 — Unmet Needs & Support Requirements: Examine the need for reminders, learning plans, recommendations, accountability, feedback, doubt resolution, mentorship, collaboration, peer support, and practical application before showing feature descriptions.
- Phase 5 — Feature Opportunity Evaluation: Introduce concise, neutral descriptions of SkillForge's proposed feature areas. Measure relevance, expected impact on completion, likely usage, trust, perceived differentiation, and control requirements.

- Phase 6 — MaxDiff Prioritisation: Present balanced subsets of five or more feature opportunities for repeated best and worst choices. The output will be a relative priority hierarchy for roadmap decisions.
- Phase 7 — Subscription Value & Pricing: Evaluate the value of certified courses plus mentorship, preferred payment structure, renewal conditions, and either Van Westendorp price perceptions or Gabor-Granger price likelihood, depending on whether candidate INR prices are available.
- Phase 8 — Educator and Creator Perspective: Route teachers, trainers, and course creators to a separate module covering content delivery, learner support, assessment quality, mentorship feasibility, and community or collaboration operations.
- Phase 9 — Closing Priorities: Capture the single improvement SkillForge should make first, the main reason respondents continue or discontinue learning, and a high-value open-ended recommendation.

Break screens may be inserted between the completion-diagnosis, feature-prioritisation, and pricing phases if field timing indicates elevated fatigue.

Key Data Points to Measure

Primary Metrics

- Online-learning incidence and recency - establishes respondent eligibility and separates active, lapsed, prospective, and educator audiences.
- Learning frequency and session duration - identifies habitual versus occasional learners and tests the role of short adaptive modules.
- Course-start-to-completion funnel - identifies whether drop-off occurs before first use, during modules, at assessments, or before certification.
- Unfinished-course incidence - quantifies the size of the completion problem and enables segment comparison.
- Completion-barrier incidence - measures the relative role of time pressure, relevance, difficulty, weak support, poor discovery, reminders, accountability, and competing work demands.
- Feature usefulness and expected completion impact - identifies which proposed features are most likely to improve outcomes rather than simply attract interest.
- MaxDiff preference shares - creates a forced-choice hierarchy across collaboration, analytics, certification, mentorship, recommendations, reminders, learning plans, community, assessments, progress tracking, and doubt resolution.
- AI analytics trust and willingness to use - measures whether learners accept skill-gap recommendations and what explanations or controls they require.
- Mentorship, collaboration, and community preference - separates expert access, peer accountability, practical teamwork, social learning, and faster doubt resolution.

- Certification value and perceived credibility - determines whether certification contributes to career progress, workplace recognition, motivation, or subscription renewal.
- Subscription value and renewal appeal - identifies the strength of the certified-course-plus-mentorship proposition.
- Price acceptability or purchase-likelihood curve - supports exploratory price-range estimation or demand-curve analysis.
- NPS or recommendation intent - provides a directional loyalty and advocacy measure for current platform users, with reason probing.

Supporting Metrics

- Course discovery source and platform repertoire.
- Self-directed versus employer-sponsored learning.
- Preferred learning topics and workplace application needs.
- Device and usage context.
- Preferred reminders and accountability mechanisms.
- Desired level of recommendation personalisation.
- Perceived explainability and control over AI recommendations.
- Sensitivity to workplace-data use.
- Preferred synchronous and asynchronous support formats.
- Mentor access expectations and acceptable response times.
- Educator perceptions of content quality, learner drop-off, assessment design, and delivery feasibility.
- Differences between SkillForge users, users of other platforms, lapsed learners, prospective learners, and educators.

Advanced Analytics We'll Apply

- MaxDiff preference-share analysis to rank feature opportunities and identify roadmap priorities.
- Funnel and drop-off analysis to locate the stages where completion declines.
- Driver analysis to examine which barriers and feature perceptions are most associated with completion intent and renewal appeal.
- Segment cross-tabulation to compare active, lapsed, prospective, other-platform, and educator audiences.
- Gap analysis to compare desired support with current platform experiences.
- AI trust segmentation to identify learners who want automated guidance, cautious assistance, or human-led recommendations.
- Price sensitivity analysis using Van Westendorp curves or Gabor-Granger demand curves, depending on the final price design.
- Thematic coding and sentiment analysis of open-ended explanations for completion, disengagement, trust, and feature priority.

- Consistency analysis to identify contradictions between reported learning frequency, recent activity, and completion behaviour.
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Expected Insights & Outcomes

By the end of this study, you will possess the data to:

- Validate whether clearer personalised learning plans and reminders are associated with higher module-completion and repeat-learning intent.
- Validate whether lapsed learners are more constrained by relevance, accountability, support, or motivation than by course length alone.
- Validate whether AI skill-gap analytics are attractive only when learners understand how recommendations are generated and how they connect to career progress.
- Validate whether mentorship and doubt resolution can improve completion more effectively than broad community features for learners who get stuck.
- Validate whether industry certification and mentor access increase perceived subscription value only when the credentials are trusted and relevant to workplace advancement.
- Validate whether real-time collaboration appeals most to learners seeking practical application, peer accountability, group projects, or help with difficult topics.
- Decide which one to three feature areas should enter the next product-design or prototype phase.
- Decide whether real-time collaboration should be positioned around peer accountability, live problem-solving, group projects, or social learning.
- Decide whether AI-driven skill-gap analytics should be prioritised for learners, managers, or both.
- Decide which trust safeguards, explanations, privacy controls, or human-review mechanisms are required before AI analytics can be adopted.
- Decide whether the certified-course-plus-mentorship subscription tier has enough differentiated value to justify further pricing and packaging work.
- Decide whether SkillForge's strongest competitive position should be practical workplace application, career development, personalised guidance, completion support, trusted certification, or a combination of these.
- Strategize how active, lapsed, prospective, other-platform, and educator audiences should receive different product and communication priorities.
- Strategize which support mechanisms should be designed first: reminders, learning plans, mentorship, doubt resolution, community, collaboration, or progress tools.
- Strategize how SkillForge can reduce switching friction and improve continued subscription use.

Key Hypotheses Being Tested

1. Learners who receive clearer personalised learning plans and reminders are more likely to complete modules.
2. Lapsed learners are more constrained by relevance, accountability, or support than by course length alone.
3. AI skill-gap analytics will be attractive only when learners understand how recommendations are generated and how they support career progress.
4. Mentorship and doubt resolution may improve completion more effectively than broad community features for learners who get stuck.
5. Industry certification and mentor access can increase perceived subscription value, but only when credentials are trusted and relevant to workplace advancement.
6. Real-time collaboration will appeal most to learners seeking practical application, peer accountability, or help with difficult topics.
7. SkillForge can improve competitive differentiation if its feature bundle addresses completion barriers more directly than existing platforms.
8. A subscription premium is more viable when certification and mentorship are perceived as career outcomes rather than simply additional content.

KPIs to Report

- Course-start-to-completion funnel and stage-level drop-off.
 - Share of learners citing each completion barrier.
 - Feature usefulness and expected completion impact.
 - MaxDiff relative-importance and preference-share scores.
 - AI analytics trust, relevance, explainability, and willingness to use.
 - Mentorship, community, collaboration, and doubt-resolution preference by learner segment.
 - Perceived value of certified-course-plus-mentorship subscription packaging.
 - Renewal appeal and subscription purchase likelihood.
 - Van Westendorp acceptable price range or Gabor-Granger demand curve, depending on the final pricing design.
 - NPS or recommendation intent among current users.
 - Differences between active learners, lapsed learners, prospective learners, other-platform users, and educators.
 - Open-ended themes explaining continuation, disengagement, trust, and feature priorities.
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Methodology See why

We will deploy a 20–25-question, approximately 8–12-minute survey on the SuperJ mobile application and the web to 400 verified Indian respondents over an indicative two-week fieldwork period.

This is a zero-stimulus, non-cell design. The questionnaire will use a modular funnel combining

U&A, completion diagnosis, feature evaluation, MaxDiff prioritisation, and exploratory pricing. If the final feature list contains fewer than five distinct opportunities, MaxDiff will be replaced with a shorter forced-choice or ranking module; no cell split will be created.

The recommended sample is 400 respondents because it provides a practical directional base for total-sample proportions and allows comparison across key behavioural routes. Results should be interpreted as directional within smaller subgroups, especially the educator and course-creator route. Current SkillForge users, other-platform users, lapsed learners, prospective learners, and educators will be identified through screening and analysed as separate segments rather than treated as one homogeneous population.

The question mix will prioritise behavioural measures and forced trade-offs, with fully labelled five-point scales for usefulness, trust, relevance, and expected impact. Open-ended questions will be limited to high-value points such as the largest completion barrier and the single improvement SkillForge should make first.

Data Collection Approach: SuperJ mobile application and web panel, with audience targeting enforced before survey start for age, gender, city, and NCCS. The questionnaire will not re-collect these targeting variables.

Quality Controls: Attention checks, speedster removal, straight-liner detection, behavioural consistency checks, randomisation of feature order, block rotation for long batteries, and open-ended gibberish filtering.

Target Audience See why

Total Sample Size: 400 respondents.

Geographic Focus: Delhi, Mumbai, Bangalore, and Hyderabad. These focused Tier 1 cities provide a concentrated view of corporate learners, digital upskillers, and professionals likely to encounter employer-supported or career-oriented online learning.

Demographics:

- Gender: 50% Male and 50% Female.
- Age Range: 18-24, 24-35, and 35-45.
- Socioeconomic Class: NCCS A1, A2, A3, B1, and B2, with emphasis on digitally active consumers who can evaluate subscription value and career-oriented learning.

Behavioral and Professional Filters:

- Existing SkillForge learners or subscribers who have recently used the platform, including high-engagement and low-completion users.
- People who have used another online course or learning platform recently.

- Lapsed or inactive online learners who have started but not consistently completed courses.
- People currently considering online learning or professional upskilling.
- Teachers, trainers, and course creators who can evaluate content quality, learner drop-off, assessment design, mentoring, and delivery feasibility.
- Respondents able to describe at least one concrete online-learning behaviour, completion experience, or course decision.

Screening Criteria:

- Must be aged 18 or above and located in India.
- Must have taken, subscribed to, taught, created, or seriously considered an online course within the relevant recent period.
- SkillForge users must report usage recency and completion behaviour before feature evaluation.
- Current learners, lapsed learners, prospective learners, other-platform users, and educators must be routed separately.
- Educator and course-creator responses must be analysed separately from learner outcomes.

The sample is balanced across gender and distributed across three supported adult age brackets to capture early-career, working-professional, and experienced-professional learning needs. The city and age distributions are independent quota dimensions, not additive across one another.